

Social Skills

Connecting with others is a learnable skill

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Connecting with others is a learnable skill

Striking up a conversation, putting others at ease, listening well, daring to approach people: these aren't innate gifts reserved for 'extroverts'. They're skills — and like any skill, they can be built.

This guide helps you understand what blocks you, ease social anxiety, and develop concrete skills to connect with ease.

Your intention

A social situation you'd like to handle better: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Where your discomfort comes from

Our social ease is built early: teasing, exclusion, socially awkward parents may have installed the idea that 'social is dangerous' or 'I'm not interesting'. That's not a truth — it's something learned.

Understanding the origin of your unease means no longer taking it as a life sentence.

Example

Teased as a child, Tom avoided groups. Understanding where his unease came from helped him stop treating it as fate.

Exercise — My social history

Which moments shaped my relationship to others? What belief did I draw from them?

My social strengths

List 3 relational qualities you already have (listening, humour, reliability...).

→ *My social discomfort is learned — so it can change.*

Social anxiety and thoughts

'I'll say something stupid', 'they'll judge me', 'I have nothing interesting to say'. These thoughts (mind-reading, the spotlight on yourself) create social anxiety and make you avoid — which keeps the discomfort going.

Testing them in real situations reduces the anxiety.

Example

Convinced she'd be 'found boring', Nia asked a colleague a simple question. The conversation flowed on its own.

Social journal

After a dreaded interaction, note: the catastrophe thought · what actually happened.

The spotlight effect

Remember: others think far less about your 'slip-ups' than you do. Note one piece of evidence.

→ *Others judge me far less than I believe. I dare.*

Being fully yourself

The best social skill is warm authenticity: being curious about the other and showing up as you are, no mask. Real bonds are born there, not in performance.

No need to play a character: your sincere presence is enough.

Example

Instead of 'playing a role', Léa allowed herself to be herself — curiosities and silences included. People grew fond of her.

Exercise — Sincere curiosity

Prepare 3 genuine open questions to ask (people love being taken an interest in).

Setting down the mask

Where do I force myself to 'perform'? What truer thing could I show?

→ I don't have to perform. Being curious and real creates the bond.

The concrete skills

A few skills make the difference: opening (a smile, a question), active listening (follow-ups, paraphrasing), finding common ground, and maintaining the bond (a follow-up message). It's practised.

You don't need to be brilliant — just present and curious.

Example

Sofia learned to follow up ('oh really, how did that go?') instead of filling silence. Her exchanges came alive.

Exercise — My toolbox

Note: 1 way to open a conversation · 2 follow-up questions · 1 way to maintain the bond afterward.

The small social challenge

Pick ONE micro-challenge this week (say hi to a neighbour, revive an exchange) and do it.

→ *Open, listen, follow up, maintain: simple moves that can be practised.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Open simply: a smile + a question about the context ('do you know this place well?').
- Listen actively: follow up ('oh, tell me more'), paraphrase, don't prepare your reply while they speak.
- Ask open questions (who, what, how): people love talking about themselves.
- Look for common ground: it's the glue of connection.
- Remember the spotlight effect: people notice your awkward moments far less than you think.
- Maintain it: a small message afterward ('great to see you') turns a meeting into a bond.

To fill in

Social journal

Date	The situation	My catastrophe thought	What actually happened

My toolbox

Open	Follow up	Maintain

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Understand my social history.

Week 2 — Test the anxious thoughts.

Week 3 — Dare authenticity.

Week 4 — Practise the skills.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The social thought I test:
- My opening question:
- My micro social challenge this week:

TO CLOSE

Connecting is a skill — and you can develop it.

With curiosity and gentleness. You learn, you practise.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not a substitute for therapy. If you are going through a hard time, please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.